



Aoraki Mt Cook towers over Mount Wakefield, as if to say "behold a real mountain" – photo by Peter Laurensen

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club - Wellington Section
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Section News

Section Nights

Please note that our first section night for 2017 is on the second Wednesday of February rather than the first Wednesday.

On **Wednesday 8th February** Jack Grinstead and Jason Blair will come and talk us about their expedition climbing Troll Finger on the Faroe Islands.

The Troll Finger Expedition

A slideshow presentation about establishing a new, direct climbing route on the iconic 313m Trøllkonufingur on the Faroe Islands



6:00pm **Wednesday 8 February** in the back room of the Southern Cross Hotel on Abel Smith Street, Wellington

Come along and hear about three New Zealanders having a wild adventure on the tiny, wacky, wonderful Faroe Islands. See photos and video from the preparation and ascent of a new, challenging climb straight out of the sea.

Please don't forget the koha for section night – there'll be an ice bucket at the entry door for that purpose. ☺

Chairs Report January 2017

If you happen to have seen this month's Economist (which I only tend to read on flights) you might have noticed the badly written Lord of the Ker-chings article by some unnamed Queenstown person. The pay for play debate for access / use of the back country appears to be warming on the back of increased numbers of tourists and (in a series of separate recent stories) the perception that deaths and accidents are also increasing – which no doubt they are – more, less experienced, people doing more stuff in the mountains equals more deaths and injuries.

Like many of you, I've travelled the world and know that many, if not most, countries charge a fee to foreigners and, sometimes, locals for management and maintenance of their parks and none of them provide the type of cover we and our tourists get from ACC. The proposal to charge tourists a flat fee on arrival, in the same way that all taxpayers contribute, regardless of whether they tramp, climb or whatever, appears to be the fairest, most manageable option. I understand this is the preferred option for Lou Sanson as well. The only resistance to this I've heard appears to be coming from the tourist industry which is worried that it will put the tourists off coming. That's a particularly short-sighted and deplorable argument not least because it is also driven by profit over preservation. You only have to look at the numbers on the Tongariro Crossing or talk to the councils on the West Coast about the turds piling up on the roadside around Fox and Franz Josef to appreciate that we can't accommodate the current influx let alone what's coming. We don't just need more money and resources to manage and prepare for this influx, we also need better policy and planning and, at the very least, an entry fee, best applied to tourists (as tax payers are already paying) on arrival. If the government can do it for pest control it can do it for tourists and it should do it now before the shit gets so high that we end up being neck deep in 100% pure crap.

If you have any comments on what you liked or didn't like send an email to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz or tweet us @NZACWellington or post a message on our facebook page www.facebook.com/nzacwellington.

Finally: “Just have one more try - it's dead easy to die,
 It's the keeping-on-living that's hard”
 Last Man Walking: Douglas Mawson

Chair: Simon Williamson
NZAC Wellington

For quick access to the section's page on the NZAC website, scan the below QR code.



Gear Hire

Don't forget the section has gear for hire : avalanche transceivers, ice axes, shovels, stakes, hammers, helmets, crampons, probes and PLBs. If you're keen to hire some gear please fill in the form [here](#). Each item costs \$5 per week with the exception of PLBs – PLBs are free but require a deposit of \$50 refundable on its return. The section is continuing to upgrade gear with new helmets, crampons and a couple of entry level ice hammers among the more recent purchases.

A little bit of advance notice would be appreciated as gear often needs to be retrieved from the gear store in Lower Hutt. Gear collections and drop-offs are usually available in the city during the working day or at section night.

Upcoming Trips, Courses and Events

Wellington Section Trips

All our planned South Island trips come with the added bonus that rental vehicle costs are covered by the section. If you're uncertain about the skill level required with any of the trips, would like to register your interest or know more email us on wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself – the committee can help with advertising / logistics.

When?	Where?
11-13 March	Paynes Ford, rock climbing – led by Eric Duggan
Easter	Mt Kensington, West Coast – details to be confirmed

Dates for our 2017 Snowcraft courses on Ruapehu will be made available soon so keep an eye on our Facebook page and your email.

Outdoor Training NZ Courses

OTNZ Wellington are running training courses as follows:

- Navigation (one evening of theory on 27 February and one field day on 5 March) - \$50
- Introductory bushcraft (24-26 March) - \$60
- Intermediate bushcraft (24-26 February) - \$80
- Advanced bushcraft (5-7 May) - \$100
- Risk Management (24-25 June) - \$70

More information on these courses and how to book your place can be found on <http://www.outdoortraining.nz/courses/courses.php>.

Trip Reports

ASPIRING TO ASPIRING

Written by Alex Waterworth

The climbing party: Simon Williamson, Carolyn Ellis, Peter Laurenson, Michael Neely, Adrian Donati, Nishil Shah and Alex Waterworth.

Halfway up French Ridge in Mt Aspiring National Park, the climbing party stalled at the edge of the snow line. The weather as expected had closed in leaving the seven climbers hut bound. Conditions were loose, slippery and putting some of the group on edge. This had nothing to do with the French Ridge snow pack but rather the state of the dunny after a rogue batch of backcountry Mexican Chicken that resulted in the quick evacuation of the bowels of anybody who ate it. This unfortunate culinary incident paved the way for non-stop toilet humour that bonded the group during an interesting week in the South Island. It's not the getting there that counts, but the journey!

Five days earlier in Wellington, we all met up to go over the plan of attack. It seemed reasonably straight forward on paper: make our way up the Matukituki Valley, take French Ridge over the top onto the Bonar Glacier and wait for a summit day at Colin Todd. Reports suggested the ramp would be stable enough to climb onto the North West Ridge and we'd all return with summit photos. Although the weather window was narrow we were all pretty pumped and it seemed an achievable goal - after all we had the whole week.

On Sunday, 13th of October we met at Christchurch airport and picked up a roomy 12 seater van and headed off to Wanaka. I'm not superstitious but it did seem like a bad omen reading a sign in the rental office that clearly stated 'beware of the ramp'.

We arrived in Wanaka in time for dinner and made a quick stop to ditch our excess gear with the Deatons, a lovely bunch who are long family friends of Adrian's. By the time we had left Wanaka and drove down the Matukituki Valley to the Raspberry Flat car park it was dark. My driving was probably slower than most on the hour long gravel road but it's easy to become distracted with a clear sky sunset in such an epic landscape, it was easy to see why people are drawn to Mt Aspiring National Park and we hadn't even left the van yet.

The walk into Mt Aspiring Hut was a pleasant one, a cool breeze kept the temperature comfortable and the light provided by the full moon only needed to be topped up by a dull head torch. The sound of cascades falling from the peaks into the river created a calming stillness and all thoughts of civilisation and the daily grind disappeared.

Monday morning, for me, came with a bitter taste. I had had the bright idea of packing spirulina to add to my prepacked bags of porridge and coconut milk powder. In hindsight, I strongly recommend testing any strange new food combination before committing to eating it for a week in the back country because, on the flavour scale, it was somewhere between foul and inedible with a similar smell and consistency! Shortly after burying the green slop and having an extra ration of scroggin we were met by the Aspiring Hut warden, Don. He gathered us around to inform us a large earthquake had shaken Wellington and killed two in Kaikoura. We organised,

through Don, to get a message back to Wellington advising we were safe and to make sure our loved ones were ok before setting off for French Ridge.

It was a short walk to Pearl Flat before an icy river crossing that provided the local sandfly population with a buffet of climbers' feet. Not wanting to overfeed the locals we got back to the task at hand which was a steep 900 meter climb to the French Ridge Hut.

It's a testing climb out of the bush up to the sub alpine on the path through a series of



Pearl Flat with French Ridge leading into the clouds on the right – Peter Laurenson



Tarns at about 1,100m on French Ridge – Peter Laurenson

twisted roots that provide both misery for your thighs and something for you to pull yourself up with. It was hard work and I learnt the hard way that I'd over packed. Reaching the first plateau

gave a rewarding view across the valley to Liverpool Hut and the lower ridges of Mt Barff. By now we'd climbed into the cloud band which was getting darker and darker by the minute. A quick burst of hail and a crack of thunder that echoed through the cirque below the Maud Francis Glacier signified the turning of the weather and, ultimately, the end of our summit attempt.



French Ridge Hut and throne pointing to Liverpool Hut across the valley – Peter Laurenson

was very keen for a brew and to get into my hut clothes when I reached French Ridge Hut but, unfortunately, the Spirulina had struck a second blow. The packet had burst and mixed with my now wet pack, caking its contents with a smelly green goo. That night after dinner (which for some was Backcountry Cuisine 'Mexican Chicken') we checked in with Don at Mt Aspiring Hut via radio who informed us there were no casualties in Wellington which was great, the weather forecast on the other hand was not.

On Tuesday morning, our options were limited by the weather so an exploratory trip up Mount French was our best bet to get onto the snow and get a feel for the conditions before committing



We reached over 2,100m but the conditions meant carrying on was a dumb idea – Peter Laurenson

to the push for Colin Todd Hutt. Climbers we'd spoken to the day before had stated conditions were excellent so with any luck we could make it over and wait for our window of opportunity. Unfortunately, Adrian had come down with a bad case of 'Mexican Chicken' automatically ruling him out of climbing that morning. The rest of us packed light and continued in the snow up the French Ridge.

Despite being on the leeward side of Mount French, the Nor'wester still had a chill as we gained altitude, it was now snowing and visibility was variable. We got to the Quarterdeck in time for a very brief spell of visibility that revealed a number of wet snow and avo trails and impressive container sized blocks of crevasse ice sticking out of the Quarterdeck. Due to the less than ideal conditions the group split with half back at the hut for lunch while the others persevered and headed further up. The rest of the day was spent in the hut with a continuous supply of hot water and tea bags brainstorming alternative plans in case the weather showed no sign of change.

It was also my turn to familiarise myself with the French Ridge dunny as last night's Mexican Chicken had finally caught up with me. There were three things that puzzled me about the French Ridge dunny. Firstly, where did that unpleasant updraft come from? Secondly, what's the point in having a giant toilet brush when clearly no one uses it and, thirdly, why was there a solitary wet sock on the floor? Was its other half sacrificed as toilet paper?

At least one of my questions was answered that night during our radio check in with Don back at Aspiring Hut. After a quick rundown of the weather forecast (which was grim), Don asked me if I could do him a favour, which was almost as grim as the weather. Apparently, the contents of the French Ridge Dunny were due to be chopper'd out in a few days time and he wanted to confirm the levels to avoid any unnecessary costs. Don walked me through the preferred method of checking the level which involved sticking your arm down the poo chute holding onto the giant toilet brush!!

On Wednesday morning we began the walk out again, a little defeated and in the rain we followed the waterfall that replaced the track we climbed up. The fresh avo debris visible that morning and watching a solid grade three crashing out of the cloud line from the direction of Mt Liverpool did more than enough to confirm in my mind we had made the right choice by walking away.

Back at Aspiring hut and out of the cloud we found sunshine again and stopped for a coffee with Don. He also needed to be briefed on the dunny levels which had been safely assessed without having to resort to the arm in the crapper method! Don is a wealth of knowledge and very approachable, generally a good bugger! If you're ever planning on making a trip to that neck of the woods I would definitely recommend contacting with him via the Wanaka DOC office for information on the conditions.

Raspberry Flats to Wanaka didn't take as long thanks to some fancy van-rally skills on Simon's part. I've never seen an overtaking manoeuvre that involves overtaking the other car mid river fording and, by the look on the tourist's face, neither had they. Luckily the windows on their little rental car were up so the bow wave that the van created was more of a playful splash! Although disappointed that we had to retreat, The Lake bar was a welcome eating hole, and they didn't mind that only half of us had shoes on. We spent that night in the Deaton's garage in Wanaka, for which we can't thank them enough. After a great sleep, we woke up to dry gear and all the bacon,

eggs and coffee we could eat. They were fantastic hosts and made us all feel very welcome. The forecast of rain put a stop on any plans of climbing the local crags, so we got back on the road heading north to Mount Cook Village and managed to squeeze into Unwin Lodge for the next few nights.

Friday morning breakfast was at 5:00am and we set out from the Tasman swing bridge at dawn to climb Mt Wakefield which seemed like our only option given the conditions. The night before, we got chatting with Mike, the chair of the Australian Section of the NZAC, and he joined us for the day.



At about 2,200m on Wakefield Ridge, looking down to Mueller Lake, Mt Sefton and the Sealy Range – Peter Laurenson

We knocked off the first 500m in an hour and a half giving a stunning view of Mount Sefton as the morning light struck. From our vantage point, Sefton stood over Mt Cook village bathed in a hue of pink with a clear sky backdrop. We reached the main ridge just shy of the true summit as conditions changed and the wind began to lift, giving us just enough time to grab some photos and a bite to eat before we had to turn back. Although only at the very southern end of the Mt Cook range the view was worth all the travel. To the east was a panoramic view encompassing Lake Tasman with Nuns Veil and the Liebig Range behind, this ran north through the Malte Brun Range which was held by the Murchison and Tasman glaciers either side. To the west, Mount Sefton and The Footstool which were now thundering house size blocks of ice hundreds of metres down the south face to the Mueller Glacier below. And at the end of the ridge, Aoraki himself, with the south face of Low Peak standing like an icy blue monolith, the knife edge wasn't visible from our position, instead only a big square face that dominated the skyline.



Mt Sefton and the Footstool, with the terminal lake of Mueller glacier below – Peter Laurenson



Near the summit of Mt Wakefield, with Mt Alex in the foreground and Aoraki Mt Cook beyond – Peter Laurenson

Coming back down through the snow was frustrating and I couldn't get far without going thigh deep in the snow and was thankful to be getting out of my crampons.

It was only an hour and a half, at the most, back to the van when we decided to take an alternative route, a shortcut perhaps! Above Mount Cook Village at 1500m is a scree slope descending 700m to the valley floor. From there we could follow the river back to the swing bridge and be at the Hermitage for happy hour.....easy! Mike, our Australian counterpart, opted to follow the track back and meet us at the van.

I love a good scree run and the first 350m were awesome with a walking pole in each hand there really was no other option in my mind but to charge it and run down the face full tilt! The second half however turned into a boulder field which didn't allow for much charging. Once we got down to the banks of the Hooker all we had to do was follow the river back to the van. The going was slower than anticipated and, with no clear path, it was, in places, a bit of a rock hopping exercise down river subsequently resulting in an expected testing of the water temperature. My testicle ascension rate confirmed that glacial water is, in fact, very cold. The bank eventually ended between the cliffs and the not so crossable River. After about 30 minutes, and don't ask me how he found it, Mike stumbled across the remnants of an old track.

I've bushwhacked out of some pretty stupid locations in the past but I score this track 11 out of 5 for roughness! Most of the time you couldn't see your feet, making the simple task of placing one in front of the other rather difficult. Also, the 'track' wound its way



Wakefield Track – Carolyn Ellis

along the cliff so when your feet missed the terra firma (and they did a lot) you'd spend a lot of time swinging around off shrubs and the occasional Matagouri for good measure!

Once we finally did get to the end of the track, we found a rather helpful sign erected by DOC advising that the track was closed, preventing public access. I was physically damaged by the end of the track, it's definitely a character builder, but I wouldn't use it again!



It had taken us an extra three hours but we were back at the van. We found a message from Mike written in the dirt on our windscreen telling us he'd waited an hour and a half before choosing to walk back to Unwin. We ended the day in Mount Cook Village drinking a few bevvies looking across the valley back up the scree slope. We took the liberty of renaming a few of the places too. The flat land between the scree and the river will now fondly be known as 'Serenity Flats', a great place to snooze while waiting for slower party members and, in honour, of Mike Neely's navigation efforts, the track (if you can call it a track) is now formally 'Neely there yet?'

Needless to say, the next day involved a later start, half the group went to Mueller Hutt for lunch and the rest of us had an easy day of walking around well preserved DOC tracks. It wasn't what I'd gone away to do but looking at glaciers and making the most of being in the Mt Cook area was great. It was windy but still reasonably sunny down in the valleys and, walking at a leisurely pace without the burden of a pack, really helped savour the views. Before the end of the day we all met back up at the Old Mountaineer and, to Simon's great displeasure, sampled the world's smallest and most expensive flat white!

The next day signalled the end of the week and the beginning of the trip back to Wellington and, what do you know, it was sunny.

During the week we never made a successfully summit of any peak we set out for, but the trip was a blast and the company I held made it for me. We made the most of each day and had a great time doing it. It's not the getting there that counts, but the journey..... but summing Aspiring would have been nice too!

Chasing the fifteenth

Words and pictures – Peter Laurenson



Contemplating the steep craggy route on the north side of Bannister



Hmmm, I don't fancy down climbing that, not on my own at least. But, if retracing my steps isn't an option, then the 'worst trail in the Tararuas' is my alternative route out now – bugger! Back in August I had been this way before, hoping to get on top of the four points over fifteen hundred metres in the Tararuas that I hadn't yet reached – there are fifteen in all. Back then poor weather and storm damage on the 'worst trail', not far on from Cow Creek Hut, had broken my resolve. Now in December, with a lot more daylight to play with and no slippery snow and ice, it dawned on me that I had had a lucky escape in August.

Since August I'd been watching for a two day weather window, which finally came just pre Christmas. Now I enjoyed excellent conditions all to myself on the tops, while also discovering just how big, as an overnigher at least, my objective was. If I'd pushed on in August, alone as I was, it would have certainly been too much. This time, to avoid the 'worst trail' – a section shown on the map skirting around a valley wall at about 800 metres between Cow Creek Hut and Arete Forks Hut, I'd planned to access the tops via Cow Saddle (670m), go all the way around to Lancaster (1,504), which would give me all fifteen high points, after having passed over Bannister's low (1,513m) and high (1,537m) peaks and Arete (1,505m) on the way. Then I could just retrace my steps. No worries. Wrong!

It's all too easy to under estimate the Tararuas. Sadly, most years people pay the ultimate price for doing this. While they don't break 1,600 metres anywhere along their length, the Tararuas are a complex network of exposed ridges and deep rugged river valleys. Between the tops and the rivers, often on very steep hillsides, is dense forest, slippery gravel, roots and mud. It rains and blows - a lot. It's not civilised, even when sticking like glue, as I do, to DoCs little orange triangles. And, once free of the bush, along the tops it can be surprisingly craggy, steep and narrow, as I discovered north of Bannister's low peak. Here, on a small near vertical section only a few metres high, as I climbed, groping for fewer hand and footholds than my comfort zone required, I realised that the exposure and lack of a companion meant that I didn't want to climb back down this way.

There was also another aspect I'd under estimated – the time needed to cover my route. To access the tops I first had to climb from Kiriwhakapapa campsite at the road end, up over the Blue Range. This requires about 800 metres of up and then 600 metres of down to Cow Creek Hut – a bit under four hours walking on the way in and an hour more on the way out due to the rigors my legs endured in between. From Cow Creek the going gets tougher as the real climb begins, first to Cow Saddle, then up a steep ridge on to the tops and Waingawa Peak (1,423m). A heap of storm damage between about 700 and 850 metres made this section extra hard going. There is a shortcut to Cow Saddle at the western end of the Blue Range track that avoids some of the descent all the way to Cow Creek Hut but, after following it for a bit, it dissolved into a labyrinth of goblin forest on a broad ridge, so I opted for the security of the orange triangles back on the main trail.

For me, the most challenging scrambling was south of Waingawa on the approach to Bannister. But there are plenty of other sections along this route that demand care and concentration. And there are many, many ups and downs. In the course of my two days I was on the move for 25 hours and ascended and descended at least 3,500 metres. By comparison, my climb of Aoraki Mount Cook a few years ago, from Plateau Hut via the Linda Glacier, took 14 hours and 1,700 metres of ascent/descent – so height above sea level is definitely not the only way to define a big day out. There are plenty of them lurking in the Tararuas.



Bannister summit (1,537m) view south west to Lancaster (1,504 - left), Arete Bivvy (1,360m - right of centre), the Twins (1,466m and 1,440m - right foreground) and Arete (1,505m - right skyline)

While it's hard work along the ridge between Waingawa and Arete, the views are worth the effort. Being on some of the highest of the Tararuas' tops, there are expansive vistas in every direction most of the time. It's only when you get up close and personal with steep sections that they seem to disappear in favour of close-ups of the next tussock or rocky handhold. From Bannister there's a clear view west over the Twins (1,466m and 1,440m) to Arete, Arete Bivy directly beneath and Lancaster a little further to the south. And east of Lancaster is Pinnacle Ridge, dropping steeply to Arete Forks, then leading away east around the 'worst trail' to Cow Creek.



The tarn just above Arete Bivy, with Bannister and the Twins left, Blue Range centre, Pinnacle Ridge right and Table Ridge right skyline

Although I didn't have to climb Arete in order to reach the bivy beneath – there's a trail that traverses across beneath Arete, I did in order to honour my goal for the trip. By the time I'd had a photo-stop on top of Arete it was nearly 6pm, 12 hours on from when I set off from Kiriwhakapapa camp site that morning. The wind had strengthened considerably, so it was a mighty pleasure to shrug off my pack on the second of the two bunks down at Arete Bivy and fire up a brew. The bivy is a little charmer and in pretty much brand spanking condition, with its own water tank and throne just a little down the tussock bench where it's situated.

With all the wind and cloud that evening I had no sunset, but the windless sunrise next morning more than made up for it. A panorama, framed to the left by Bannister and to the right by Lancaster, takes in a sea of layered ridges stretching out across the Wairarapa. The tranquillity put me in a good frame of mind for the rigors still to come.



Arete Bivy – a 2 bunk charmer at 1,360m





Dawn view south east from Arete Bivy to the Blue Range

I was away by about 7am and the first stretch south to Lancaster was easy and a joy to walk in the early morning sunlight. Lancaster is one of the easier 1,500 metre points to finish chasing the fifteen on, but satisfying nevertheless. Another round of summit shots captured yet more huge vistas in all directions. My immediate concern though, was not knowing just how tricky Pinnacle Ridge would be to descend. The view on the approach looked near vertical in a few places.



View east from beneath Lancaster down the steep, rugged Pinnacle Ridge, with the Blue Range behind. Bannister is far left

As it turned out, the steepest section is coming directly off Pinnacle itself. The rest is not as challenging as the steep sections north of Bannister, although below the bushline, it is relentlessly, toenail destroyingly steep. More than 800 metres below Lancaster, down at Waingawa River, wading across bare-footed to reach Arete Forks Hut soothed things down a bit after nearly four hours of toil. Now my concern was the 'worst trail'. How tough is 'worst'? How much storm damage?

After a brew in the shade of Arete Forks Hut it was time to face the music. Into the bush and straight up. For the next four hours I descended to, then ascended from streams that have cut deep gullies into the valley wall. Six streams, six ups, six downs, adding at least 500 metres of ascent and descent. And not easy going – very steep, loose rubble, root infested and sometimes obstructed by big, shattered, storm-felled trees. Keeping on route demanded constant concentration and delays. If it had been wet I would have muttered even more four letter words than I did. 'Worst trail in the Tararuas'? Though not having trodden all of them, I can believe it!

I was relieved to reach Cow Creek Hut, where I knew that all that now remained was a four or so hour slog back up over Blue Range to my car. Near the top of Blue Range I met the only people I encountered during the two days. They probably wondered why I plodded up the ridge like a poorly oiled, battery depleted robot. It had been a big two days, befitting the effort needed to reach the fifteen 1,500ers of the Tararuas. End result - stuffed, but happy.



Goblin forest at about 900m on the Blue Range trail

See more at

<http://www.occasionalclimber.co.nz/browse-images-2/new-zealand-north-island/tararuas-browse/bannister-circuit-december-2016/>

Higher Alpine Skills Course, Mt Cook National Park, 20 - 25 November 2016

By Paul McCredie

"Who knows how to rope up for glacier travel?" enquired Paul. Receiving a pitiful three out of seven from the assembled, he turned to fellow instructor Anna - "We've got a problem here".

Yes, it was true, we were hardly the Magnificent Seven. Our experience ranged from the ridiculously (double vs single rope debate) overqualified, down to the "how does a clove hitch go again?" novice. But ranging in age from 31 to 64 with two mechanical engineers, an emergency doctor, a paramedic, a gliding instructor and a farmer, surely we had a few other bases covered?

And don't get Paul started on our gear. Possibly the most stressful part of the HASC is assembling the necessary equipment - especially when you don't have a mate to bludge the big ticket items from. Somehow we'd all managed to cobble together an approximation of the requisite kit but that didn't stop Paul likening our gear reveal to the Antiques Roadshow.

Asolo full plastic boots from the eighties, Mallory's ice screws that went straight in the rubbish, some slings of dubious strength and best of all, a beautiful Chouinard wooden handled ice pick that had guides queuing to buy for their mantelpiece.

Fortunately it was blowing a gale at Mt Cook Village that first day with no chance of a helicopter fly in. Instead, we were dispatched to the Hooker Bridge for a crash course in all things glacier followed by a rock climbing refresher at the Sebastopol bluffs. For those of us who'd recklessly left their climbing shoes at home it was a sobering experience tackling the easy routes in cumbersome climbing boots.

Clouds were still racing across the sky the next day as we made futile trips to the airport in between lectures on avalanches and meteorology. By now it was apparent that the weather pattern for the week was changeable at best. The chances of getting a helicopter drop off on the high plateau decidedly iffy and the likelihood of a pick up even more remote.

"But hey, it could be worse" said Paul gesturing to a suave looking American staring morosely into his chardonnay, "he's just dropped 6 to 8K into climbing Mt Cook and it's not gonna happen".

It was time for a new plan. The next two days presented the best opportunity to summit. But with a limited chance of getting in and out of a high level hut, Paul and Anna opted to chopper up Gorilla Stream to a rock biv and an assault on The Nuns Veil.



Bivvy site - Gorilla Stream

I was loath to leave the luxury of Unwin Lodge but the raw stark beauty of the narrow valley quickly won me over. We spent the afternoon building anchors and figuring out what to do with 'the infinity loop' - a sling of epic dimensions that Francois had been assured by the hipster at a

Melbourne gear shop was "just right for NZ alpine conditions".



Off to a predawn start, we soon hit the glacier and roped up like seasoned climbers. A high overnight freezing level meant that crampons weren't needed as we slogged up the pristine slope that had

stood in for the Lhotse Face in a recent TV dramatisation of Ed Hilary's life.

High above we could make out the tiny ant like figures of NZAC President Penny Brothers quartet tentatively traversing below the summit having camped overnight on the high col.

Stopping for a break just 200 meters below the top, Anna and Paul recognised it was time for the less experienced of us to call it a day. The extra time to build anchors on the final push would mean descending late in the day when the avalanche danger of the Lhotse Face would be at its highest.



Heading back to camp - Penny's group descending from the summit in the shadows in the background

Instead, Carl and Anna made a lightening quick free climb to the summit while the rest of us returned to camp and some serious sun bathing. A few hours later we were rudely awakened by Penny and her gold card holders triumphant victory march down the valley.

Back at the Lodge, with only one fine day left before the weather closed in for good, it was decided to climb to Mueller Hut. Just before the ridge we found a slope that allowed crampons to fitted for the first time all week. The stunning Mt Sefton and Hooker Valley made a magnificent backdrop to a final crevasse extraction exercise - no wonder every foreign tourist has their heart set on a night in Mueller Hut. Then again many of them were probably just as bemused by our antics as we were of their choice of sneakers and jeans in the alpine environment.

By the time of our final debrief the next day we were a tight knit team where knowledge was freely shared but just how a discussion on the merits of strap on crampons segued to the most degenerate scene from the film Acid House is hard to tell. All week Paul and Anna did an excellent job keeping us busy in trying circumstances and as Anna diplomatically put it, "you've been fast learners!"

Participants - Robin Barraclough, Peter Bell, Francois Fouche, James Knudsen, Paul McCredie, Frank Saxton and Carl Walker

Instructors - Paul Rogers and Anna Keeling

And Pigs Can Climb

By Jenny Cossey

Pig decided that a weekend soiree to Golden Bay would be a refreshing change to life in the Hutt Valley, and sneaked on board an Air NZ flight bound for Nelson, stowed away between a tent and climbing rack, in a rather abused rucksack on the Wellington NZAC trip. He remained in his hide-ee-hole until the hairpin bends of Takaha Hill gave way to the flatter land of Golden Bay and he at last arrived at Hangdog in the twilight of the day. Gasping for some fresh air in the golden light, he surveyed the campground and noted there were predominantly Kiwis about as three separate Wellington rock climbing groups drifted into the camp as the sun faded.

The dawn chorus was earlier than in the Hutt, and the snug tent now felt crowded with three males, and a pig. They burst out into the daylight and deciding that damp feet from the morning dew did not become a pig who chose to spent the day indoors, under a tent fly, and admire the young spring oak leaves unfurling above him.



The humans were a bit more tenacious and rallied to the early morning rise by hastening to the crags before the sun arrived to warm them. The cold, still air remained all morning, and the discussion about a lie-in the following day and sun at the Seawall with the other half of the NZAC meet might have been a warmer call. The crags were very empty of people and patience was the order of the day while ropes were set, belayers climbed, views were admired and Eric did an incredible grade twenty backward somersault just above the first bolt, arriving head first with feet over his head in a hanging position about the level of the belayer's knees, who gently slid sideways off the belay rock to hang below him.

A cool afternoon, perfect for cragging and pig continued to admire lying in the sun, admire the cherry blossom, the new reeds growing in the grey water bed and calculated his dining table was strategically placed to receive the last evening rays of sunlight at the camp ground. His mates returned tired and happy, regaling stories of each route, their merits and challenges, personal achievements and sorrows. So many stories, pig was asleep before they had finished. The fire embers were bright, the stars shone above and a frost fell on the surrounding hills, as the Wellington brigade crept off to tents and the bunk house to lay their weary bodies horizontal.

A sleepy start to Sunday was had by all. Pig resisted getting his trotters wet, rolled over and sun basked on his mat, listening to the daily rhythm or the road traffic behind the hedge and pondered the meaning of life. All the other Hutt Valley folk and Wellingtonians headed to Paynes Ford crags for the day. Warmer than yesterday, no wind, a perfect day as the rocks did not receive any sun to mid-afternoon so all crags could be climbed at any time. Late in the afternoon all the group joined up at a wall where ropes were shared, bolts were clipped, hanging chains backed up by slings and everyone able to watch each other's stylish ascents.

Pig lazed on, rolling over when the humans returned and prepared food for the trough. The local hot tub and sauna were frequented under a starry sky and late night drama games gave everyone hysterics around the fire pit with a fire burning bright. Pig slept on.

Labour Day and Pig's tent was rolled up. Pig chose to be cocooned in a day pack, hoping to rest in a sunny spot and be entertained by human antics, rather than a day smelling the air freshener in the hire car boot.

It began to dawn on Pig that he was going on an adventure as the ascent to base camp began. He was in the company of three Sherpa's, a guide, provisions and talk of great views from the top. He rested a while as the team sorted out ropes and hardware, had warm up climbs and discussed routes; the arm stretches involved, feet placements and the rationing of food supplies. In the name of safety, Pig was short roped to his guide, who then plugged his way up the near vertical face in true expedition style with numerous rests, admiring the views, discussion of route possibilities and discussing how everyone was feeling about life, with Pig being carried outward facing on his back to get the best views. Pig managed to out climb three others who attempted the west ridge line to his summit at the same time and posed at the top for his photography.



Weary from his ascent Pig spent the remainder of the day resting and bathing in his glories and the sunshine as he was driven back over the hill, flown over the water and headed home to the Hutt.

Annual Tukino Climbing Camp

Written by Eric Duggan, photos by Eric Duggan

The annual Tukino Climbing Camp was held in early January over 4 days. The weather was much better than forecast and fine every day – although on the first day we had very strong winds and it was quite cold.



Bowie Rickman Slabs Mangatoetoenui Gorge

The routes on the Bowie Rickman Slabs in the Mangatoetoenui Gorge were a highlight. There are a number of 2 or 3-star slab routes that go at about grade 17 and 30m in length. Most of these are bolted with the odd bit of gear and lots of bollards and gear placements for anchors at the top.

Another highlight is the 55m grade 12 route Scrambled Egg near the start of the TASC Master wall. This has 6 bolts and some good gear placements higher up and is a good first trad lead with a real alpine feel to it.



Mac Duggan leading Scrambled Eggs

Richard Knott put up two new routes at the start of the TASC Master wall. A grade 17 and 18, both with a couple of bolts at the start and good gear higher up and for the belay.

Mac and Angus Duggan developed a number of boulder problems on the boulders between TASC and Aorangi Lodge. One of the highlights is Kneel Hook at V1 which has quite a desperate move!



Angus Duggan on Low Ball Mantle



Mac Duggan on Kneel Hook

Notices

Events at Unwin Lodge, Mt Cook

Waitangi Weekend

Weeding / windows washing working bee – 1 free night for one adult per half-day labour

Saturday 4 February - Pat Morrow (<http://patmorrow.com/who>) is over from Canada and is doing a talk - [Hobnail Boots and Hemp Rope slide show](#) on the Conrad Kain 100 year anniversary of Bugaboo Spire first ascent. 7:30pm at Aoraki Mt Cook Community Hall – gold coin donation and a plate for supper. See <https://youtu.be/UrRDb8Kfv0U>

Pot luck Blues BBQ on Sunday 5 February – BYO BBQ contribution, dress up in something “blues” and bring along a musical instrument for a bit of a jam session.

Autumn – Unwin replanting project – date to be confirmed – late March / early April. A number of existing plants need to be relocated around the lodge based on a revised planting plan. If you're available to provide some people power for a weekend let Pip know.

March – for all of those budding artists – a weekend painting trip to Plateau Hut – contact Pip for more details (pipandsimon@gmail.com) – some alpine experience necessary.

New Book – The sharp end of a short rope

Graham Langton has written about the first forty years of the NZ Mountain Guides Association - \$40: <https://alpineclub.org.nz/product/the-sharp-end-of-a-short-rope/>

Research Project: Rock Climbing Injuries

Sam Terry has completed his research project on rock climbing injuries towards his Bachelor of Sport and Exercise at SIT. Please view his published results for your information on the NZAC website: <https://alpineclub.org.nz/research-project-rock-climbing-injuries/>

Thanks to all who participated in the survey that aided Sam to complete his report.

NZAC 2107 Calendar and 125th Anniversary Clothing – Sale

The remaining stock of NZAC 125th Anniversary clothing and the NZAC's 2017 Photographic Comp Calendar are now on sale. Please see the club's online store for details on remaining clothing sizes/colours and to purchase: <https://alpineclub.org.nz/online-shop/>

Member Discounts

For more information on all the discounts available to NZAC members have a look at : <https://alpineclub.org.nz/membership-benefits/member-discounts/>

Below are some specific discounts you might be interested in:

Medical supplies and first aid courses:

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/company/peak-safety/>

Yoga, pilates and massage in Queenstown:

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/company/sherwood-yoga-and-wellbeing-queenstown/>

Life Insurance:

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/living-in-new-zealand/life-insurance/>

Wellington Section 2017 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Contact
Chairperson	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Co Chair	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Treasurer (Acting)	Peter Laurensen	
Secretary & Vertigo editor	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Patron	John Nankervis	
Other Committee Members	Elisha Watson	
	Matt Pemberton	
	Sandy Britain	
	Scott Wotring	
Rock Drill Overseer	Jeremy Tries	027 55 55 893

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\$1000 worth of new holds in Jan/Feb 2012

New pad in "Da Cave" allowing safe aggressive bouldering

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* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



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